Terms of Reference

Cryosphere Finance Dialogue

The Decade of Action for Cryospheric Sciences (2025-2034)

Background

On August 13, 2024, the United Nations General Assembly adopted Resolution 78/321, proclaiming 2025 to 2034 as the Decade of Action for Cryospheric Sciences. The resolution aims to accelerate efforts to address the urgent challenges posed by the melting cryosphere through enhanced scientific research, monitoring, and international cooperation. The resolution highlights the need to understand the cryosphere's role in the Earth's climate system, freshwater resources, ecosystems, and human social, political, and economic activities. It also calls for raising awareness of cryospheric loss and encourages the sharing of best practices to build resilience against related risks. Member States, UN bodies, and stakeholders are invited to support these activities. UNESCO is tasked with leading implementation of the Decade, with other UN organizations and partners, using voluntary contributions to develop programmes.

In 2025, an Ad Hoc Strategic Management Committee was convened by UNESCO to define the governance and operational structures of the Decade. The resulting Synthesis Document (UNESCO, 2026) sets out the vision of the Decade, "Science and Action for a Melting World", and identifies five Overarching Challenges (OCs):

- OC1. Global Cryosphere Monitoring
- OC2. Actionable Cryosphere Projections
- OC3. Cryospheric Risk Management Solutions
- OC4. Adaptation to Cryosphere Loss
- OC5. Amplify the Impact of Cryospheric Science

Working Groups aligned with each OC are the primary engines of delivery of the Decade. The Decade is structured around three triennia, each ending in a Triennial Cryosphere Summit. The present Terms of Reference were revised in May 2026 to reflect the decisions taken by the Ad Hoc Strategic Management Committee at its 2nd Meeting (12 May 2026), in particular concerning the leadership and organisational framework of the Working Groups, the Cryosphere Finance Dialogue and the Alliance for the Cryosphere.

The Cryosphere Finance Dialogue (CFD) is established as part of the governance and partnership architecture of the Decade. The accelerating loss of glaciers, snow, permafrost and ice sheets poses systemic risks to water security, disaster resilience, ecosystems and livelihoods at global and regional scales. The success of the Decade depends on its ability to facilitate access to relevant funding opportunities, while strengthening alignment and coordination across diverse funding sources in research, climate finance, development and philanthropy. The CFD is the dedicated mechanism to address this challenge, facilitating dialogue between the Decade's scientific community and funding actors, improving visibility of relevant funding opportunities and potential synergies, ensuring that financing constraints do not become a barrier to the delivery of the Decade's objectives and long-term legacy.

Objectives

The Cryosphere Finance Dialogue aims to:

- improve the coherence, coordination and effectiveness of financing for cryosphere-related activities under the Decade;
- bridge the gap between scientific priorities and funder requirements by translating knowledge needs into policy- and investment-relevant terms;
- facilitate connections between funders and evidence-based and nature-based solutions, and away from speculative or scientifically unsupported interventions, including the explicit exclusion of geoengineering research or deployment, in line with the Synthesis Document;
- facilitate alignment between existing funding streams and with the Decade's strategic priorities;
- strengthen the sustainability and equity of investments in cryosphere science, monitoring, adaptation and capacity-building.

Mandate and deliverables

The Cryosphere Finance Dialogue is mandated to facilitate access to relevant funding opportunities and support the alignment of financial resources but not directly manage or them. Its key deliverables include:

- An orverview of cryosphere-relevant funding streams, national science foundations, multilateral development banks, climate finance mechanisms (e.g. GCF, GEF, Adaptation Fund), philanthropic sources, regional initiatives (e.g. EU DG RTD, Arctic Science Funders' Forum), and their alignment with the Decade's objectives, drawing where possible on existing information and inputs from participating funders to improve visibility of relevant opportunities;
- guidance to facilitate connections between funding sources and relevant activities, distinguishing core coordination needs from implementation financing (following the two-track financing approach of the Synthesis Document);
- identification of financing gaps, opportunities and barriers, including policy, institutional and technical constraints;
- funder-relevant narratives linking cryosphere science to climate adaptation, disaster risk reduction, water security and sustainable development;
- periodic synthesis reports to the Strategic Management Committee, informing strategic adjustments and stakeholder engagement;
- science-based guidance to funders and policy-makers on investment decisions, including the assessment of risks, uncertainties and potential maladaptation associated with proposed cryosphere-related interventions.

Structure

The Cryosphere Finance Dialogue operates under the overall guidance of the Decade's Strategic Management Committee.

a) **Leadership**

The CFD is led by:

- a Lead, appointed for an initial three-year term;
- two Associate Leads, appointed for an initial three-year term;
- a Secretariat hosted within UNESCO Bureau of Strategic Planning, ensuring institutional anchorage and interoperability with UNESCO finance and partnership instruments.

b) Membership

The CFD adopts a flexible core membership, determined by the Lead, Associate Leads and Secretariat in consultation with the broader Dialogue, on the basis of expertise and institutional relevance rather than formal representation.

To support both a trusted exchange among funders and an effective connection with the wider Decade, the CFD will be structured around two complementary groups:

- ***Core group***

The Core Group shall be composed of funding entities, providing a space for exchange among funders, identifying potential synergies and improving coordination across relevant funding communities.

Membership may include:

- representatives from national funding agencies and research councils;
- multilateral development banks and climate finance mechanisms;
- regional funders' coordination mechanisms;
- philanthropic foundations and private-sector actors with relevant mandates;
- representatives of the IPY5 funders group, to strengthen synergies with other relevant funding streams and maximise complementarity and impact.

- ***Expert and advisory group***

The Expert and Advisory Group will provide scientific, technical and strategic input to the Dialogue, help connect the CFD with the priorities emerging across the Decade, and support the dissemination of relevant funding opportunities through appropriate networks.

Membership may include:

- scientific and technical experts with experience in programme design and funding alignment,
- one representative from each of the Decade's Working Groups observers from relevant international initiative
- members of the Strategic Management Committee, as appropriate.
-

The two groups will interact regularly and compose the full CFD.

c) Term, rotation and continuity

Leadership positions are appointed for an initial three-year term, aligned with the three triennia of the Decade and the Triennial Cryosphere Summits, with a transitional overlap of up to six months between outgoing and incoming officers.

Modus Operandi

The Cryosphere Finance Dialogue shall meet primarily online on a periodic basis, complemented by in-person meetings aligned with major international events where relevant.

At least one joint meeting per year shall be held with all the other Working Groups to foster cross-cutting coordination, share progress, align activities across Overarching Challenges and avoid duplication of effort.

Progress and outputs shall be reported biannually by the Lead, Associate Leads and Secretariat to the Strategic Management Committee, and showcased at each Triennial Cryosphere Summit.

Draft agendas and documents shall be circulated in advance of each meeting. Decisions shall be reached by consensus. Members may engage with their respective networks and constituencies, as appropriate, to support relevant information-sharing and connections. The Lead serves as a member of the Strategic Management Committee and maintains regular contact with the UNESCO IHP Decade Secretariat.

The CFD shall work in close coordination with the five thematic Working Groups to help translate emerging priorities into funder-relevant terms, facilitate early consideration of funding opportunities and potential synergies, and support information-sharing and dialogue with the Alliance for the Cryosphere.

In line with the Synthesis Document, the Cryosphere Finance Dialogue shall not endorse, fund, promote or otherwise legitimise geoengineering research or deployment, recognising the scientifically uncertain and potentially harmful nature of such interventions. Activities shall embed Indigenous and local knowledge ethically, with consent, recognition and benefit-sharing, and shall comply with UNESCO rules and procedures.

The Cryosphere Finance Dialogue shall actively articulate its work with the International Polar Year (IPY 2032–2033), the UN Decade of Ocean Science for Sustainable Development (2021–2030), the International Decade of Sciences for Sustainable Development (2024–2033), and other relevant initiatives, to maximise synergies and avoid duplication.

Website and further details

Proceedings of the Decade, consultation summaries and deliverables will be published on the Decades official website: www.un-cryosphere.org